



ERIK AZULAY, EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR, NEXUS

“Nexus serves as a central hub for entrepreneurs, innovators, faculty, government agencies, industry players, and funding organizations interested in gathering, interacting, and collaborating to promote Indian startups and the local entrepreneurial ecosystem. If you are involved with startups in India, Nexus is a place for you!”

access to industry networks and other government partners, it also includes specialised training from commercialisation experts across the world and eventual access to private and public fund managers that allow an influx of much-needed cash into startups. Erik Azulay, Executive Director at Nexus and President of ACIR told Digit, “Nexus is the first-ever initiative by the U.S. government across the globe, but due to its success is now being considered as a blueprint for similar programs in other Embassies around the world”. He also informed us that ACIR is responsible for the management and operations of Nexus which includes setting the curriculum, selecting startups, and arranging classes and partnerships for Nexus.

Nexus selects about 12-15 startups for their ‘pre-incubation training’ program under a group termed as ‘cohort’. The pre-incubation training program is an intensive 9-week practical business training program for all the chosen early-stage startups which provides them with holistic training covering important aspects of business such as primary research for business validation, marketing, intellectual property, funding, finance, and pitching. As aforementioned, the curriculum is designed by ACIR and is even customised based on the needs of Indian startups. Before the COVID-19-induced lockdown across the country, the selected startups would physically attend the training

program in the Nexus headquarters in New Delhi. Now, of course, the training program has shifted course to adjust to the new normal by transforming the 9-week physical program to a purely online experience.

Azulay explained, “With 100 per cent of our staff working from home since March 2020, we are happy to announce that we have successfully transformed our physical program to an online program and we recently completed our 10th Cohort, which

was our first entirely virtual Cohort consisting of 15 startups”. With the 10th Cohort successfully completed, Nexus is now accepting applications for its 11th Cohort. The curriculum has also been transformed to suit online sessions better by incorporating additional activities and interactions that attempt to make online sessions as engrossing as physical ones. All the workshops also discuss how startups can continue to grow their businesses during the new normal. Sessions such as ‘How to pitch on Zoom’ and tutorials for using other online tools, integral during a pandemic, were also included.

All the selected startups in the Nexus Incubator program must complete the online course, the ACIR – Startup Launch Program, which consists of assignments and quizzes. They also judge startups on the following criteria including attendance, participation and contribution during sessions, punctuality, and others. Startups who fulfil all the criteria to graduate from the program become eligible for Nexus’ long-term incubation. As part of the long-term incubation, 3-4 startups are offered a

co-working space and also receive continued mentorship for an additional eight months at Nexus. After graduation, all the startups are inducted into Nexus’ Alumni Network and receive updates on funding and partnership opportunities that could benefit their businesses. They are even invited to Nexus Alumni events where the startups can meet ones from newer and older Cohorts and build relevant and beneficial connections. Suchin Jain, Founder of Inovicia Consulting & Services, which was part of Cohort 8 in the Nexus Incubator program, told Digit,



The Nexus Startup Hub team – Vikas Sood, Director at Nexus (extreme left), Visalakshmi Ray, Project Coordinator (2nd from left), Malika Taneja, Administrative Program Manager (2nd from right), Erik Azulay, Executive Director at Nexus (extreme right)